

Skills Summary

Reading Scaled Picture and Bar Graphs

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Picture Graphs: Read the Scale First

Rule: In a scaled picture graph, one symbol stands for *more than one* thing. The key tells you how many.

$$\text{amount} = \text{number of symbols} \times \text{what one symbol stands for}$$

Example: In a picture graph, each sun symbol stands for 3 sunny days. A month's row shows 6 sun symbols. How many sunny days is that?

Step 1. The key says one symbol is worth 3 days, so multiply the symbols by the scale instead of counting symbols as ones.

Step 2. $6 \times 3 = 18$.

That row shows **18** sunny days.

Try it: Each flower symbol stands for 4 flowers. A row shows 5 flower symbols. How many flowers is that?

check: 20 flowers

Bar Graphs: Count by the Scale Steps

Rule: Find where the bar *ends*, then read that spot on the number line. When the number line skips (by twos, fives, tens), count the gridline steps and multiply by the step size.

Example: On a bar graph the number line counts by twos. The bar for “red” ends 3 gridline steps above zero. How many red things is that?

Step 1. Each gridline step is worth 2, so multiply the steps the bar climbs by the step size.

Step 2. $3 \times 2 = 6$.

The red bar shows **6**

Try it: The number line counts by fives, and the “blue” bar ends 4 gridline steps above zero. How many blue things is that?

check: 20

Compare Two Bars or Rows

Rule: “How many *more*” or “how many *fewer*” means read *both* amounts from the graph, then **subtract**: bigger – smaller.

Example: A bar graph shows 14 blue ribbons and 9 green ribbons. How many more blue ribbons than green ribbons are there?

Step 1. Comparing two amounts from the graph means subtracting the smaller bar from the bigger one.

Step 2. $14 - 9 = 5$.

There are **5** more blue ribbons.

Try it: A graph shows 16 apples and 7 pears. How many more apples than pears are there?

check: 6 more apples

(!) Watch out: Do not count symbols or gridlines as *ones* without checking the key. One symbol can stand for 5 books; one gridline step can stand for 2 pets. Reading the scale first is the whole game.